How to *win* the hackathon

Every team gets the same brief and clock. Foldo does the building. This page covers the rest.



THE RULES

1
Build for the judges, not the brief.

The rubric and the panel decide what wins. Read both first, tie each feature to a line of the rubric, and name sponsor tools aloud.

2
Build something that has only just become possible.

Ask why nobody could have built this two years ago. If the answer is AI, show it doing the work, live.

3
One person, one problem, one wow moment.

PAYMENTS
A trader waiting days for a payout.

ACCESS TO FINANCE
A renter with no credit file.

FRAUD & SECURITY
A parent about to pay a fake invoice.

Pick one. Protect the moment their problem disappears.

4
Build the demo path first.

Start from your track's template. Your first prompt is the screen judges will see. Messages are capped daily per team, so spend them there.

5
Put a number on screen.

"Flagged in 0.4 seconds" outlasts any adjective. Use real-looking names and amounts, and say what is mocked.

6
Freeze early. Keep a backup video.

Judges open your shared link, so rehearse on it from another laptop. Most phones can't run Foldo apps. Record a clean run in case the wifi fails.

The 2-minute demo

0:00	"Meet *[name]*. *[Their problem, with a number]*."
0:15	"Until now, *[why it couldn't be done]*. Now *[what changed]*."
0:30	One flow, live. Wow moment by 1:20. Narrate what they can't see.
1:30	"Real: *[this]*. Mocked: *[that]*. Under the hood: *[how]*."
1:45	"*[Who]* pays, because *[why]*. Next: *[one step]*." Stop. Leave the link up.

> *"Judges remember numbers."*
>
> FOLDO FIELD NOTES

DON'T

- × Open with the team or the slides.
- × Show the code.

THE TIMELINE

START
Read the rubric and judges' bios. Pick a track, a person, a wow moment.

FIRST HOUR
Prompt the demo screen with sample data. Fix what breaks before adding anything.

HALFWAY
Watch an outsider use the link unaided. Imagine you lost, and fix the reason.

FINAL HOUR
Feature freeze. Write the script, record the backup, rehearse twice, timed.

30 MINUTES BEFORE JUDGING
Hands off. List it in the gallery. Open the link on the demo laptop.